



YOU ARE **37 WEEKS AND 6 DAYS**

15 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

Estimating your baby's size by measuring from the top of the uterus to the front of your pelvic bone is less accurate now. Your baby may not yet have moved down into the pelvis and the amount of fluid around your baby is variable.

“Newborn babies can tightly hold someone's finger because of the grasp reflex, and this is already functioning in the uterus.”

Inside the uterus, your baby has developed a strong grasp reflex. The grip is so strong after birth that it could support your baby's weight. This grasp reflex persists until your baby is about six months old; they will then have more choice over whether to grasp an object or not.

Interestingly, your baby also has a similar reflex in the foot. This is the “plantar reflex” and it causes the toes to attempt to curl around your finger if the sole of the foot is stroked. The plantar reflex takes slightly longer to disappear after birth, typically persisting until 12 months of age. Another reflex action causes the toes to spread out if the side of the foot is stroked. These reflexes and others seem to be quite primitive in nature and although they are thought to protect the baby, the precise function of each reflex is not fully understood.

SECOND LABORS

Second labors are usually shorter in duration than first labors. This usually means an easier labor, but a second baby could be bigger than a first, or positioned differently. There are many factors to consider.

ASK A DOCTOR

Is it true that natural or water births are best for the baby? Most childbirth experts would agree that a straightforward vaginal birth is the safest form of birth for both mother and baby. It is also generally considered safe to use water as a method of relieving the pain in uncomplicated labors.

However, it is sometimes not possible to achieve a straightforward vaginal delivery due to certain situations that can arise during labor and birth. If a problem with either the mother or baby occurs, the medical team will advise you on the safest way of delivering the baby.

It's important to think about the type of birth you would prefer, but be prepared to be flexible and to see how labor unfolds. Ask your doctor if there's a birthing pool you can use at your